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THE CHRONICLE OF HIGHER EDUCATION

This Week in Higher Ed

This week's must-read: Oregon State University put its chips on computer science. It lost $19 million.



The Computer-Science Gamble

By Francie Diep

The students started noticing when the Discord, subreddit, and internal chat platform they used went quiet.

Between the spring of 2025 and the spring of 2026, Oregon State University lost nearly 1,000 computer-science majors, or 23 percent of its overall enrollment in the field. The drop-off was especially steep in its online programs, which lost 30 percent of their students. Computer science is the university's most popular major, and the "melting down" of that enrollment

university's most popular major, and the "melting down" of that enrollment was so significant that during a board meeting in March, Jayathi Y. Murthy, Oregon State's president, told trustees it was responsible for a $19-million budget shortfall.

"I go to a lot of TA tutoring," said Teodoro Partida, a case manager at a nonprofit in Chicago who last year started a bachelor's program in computer science through Oregon State's Ecampus. "I was seeing less of my peers at those as more time went by."

Oregon State, of course, is part of a national trend. For two decades, students from elementary school on up were told that the future was in learning to code. Enrollment in computer science rose accordingly.

Then, in late 2022, OpenAI released ChatGPT. At first, Chat stunned the public with its naturalistic conversations, but soon it became clear that another of its strengths was writing code. If agentic AI has thrown all of higher ed into an existential crisis — *What's the purpose of college, if AI can digest books/write essays/tutor students?* — it has done so especially for computer-science departments.

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